No Vacancy

SRO HOTELS AND GENTRIFICATION IN UPTOWN

Abstract: This is a research project on Single-Room Occupancy housing in Chicago's Uptown neighborhood. For this assignment, I investigated an area of my choosing and researched an urban development issue affecting residents. I analyzed income data in my neighborhood and discovered two adjacent block groups with an income disparity of ~$80,000. Through further research, I explored the complicated history of SRO hotels and their role in preventing complete homelessness, despite their poor living conditions.

This project investigates the history of SRO housing in Uptown, analyzes the area's wealth and demographic data, and presents policy solutions to ensure transitional housing remains under the control of local affordable housing developers and advocacy organizations.

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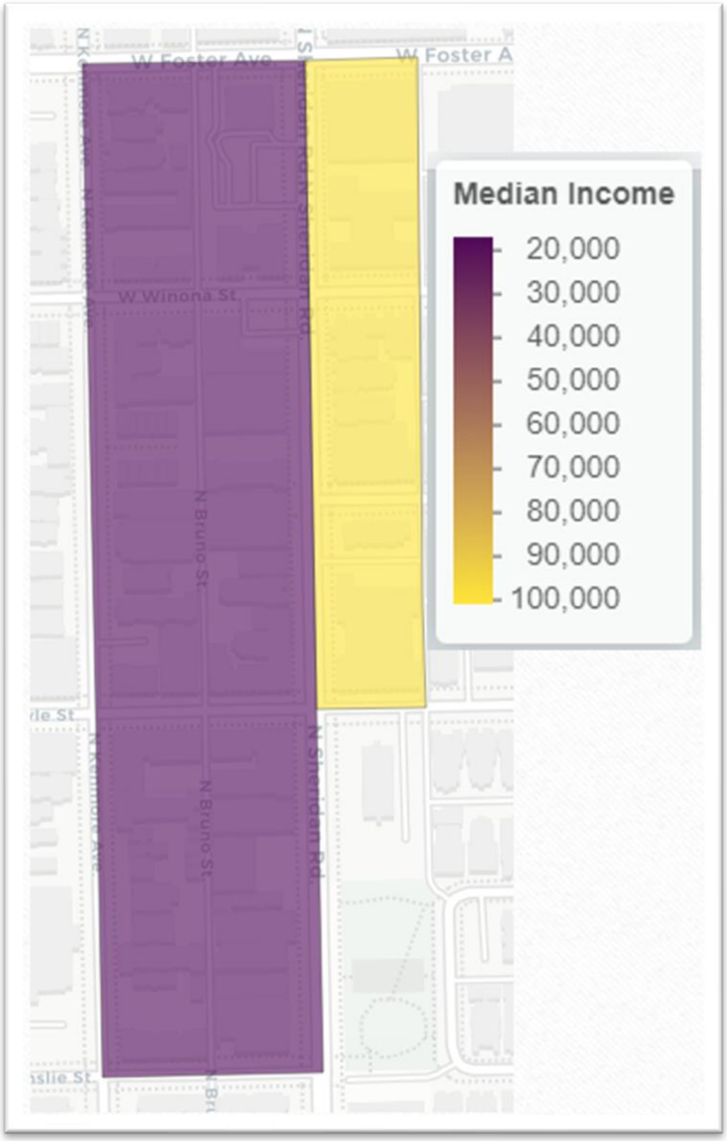


Housing is becoming unsustainable in Uptown. As the neighborhood improves and receives new development, affordable housing is disappearing. Residents who are facing homelessness are running out of options.

The area I researched is the unofficial border between Argyle Historic District and Margate Park. Balmoral to the north, Broadway to the west, Anslie to the south, and Lake Michigan to the east define the boundary.

The two block groups on this graph are a prime example of the wealth disparity in Uptown. The one in yellow, which I will refer to as the High-Income block group, has a median income of over $100,000 and contains a former luxury hotel turned market-rate apartments. The block group in purple has a median income of less than $20,000 and contains two of the few remaining Single-Room Occupancy hotels in Chicago. These block groups are right across the street from each other but are in two completely different worlds. There are only two of the twelve block groups in the area I researched, but these two will serve as the focal point for the project.

This area personifies the struggles Uptown has faced in its 100-year history: the struggle between rich and poor, development and displacement. The history of this neighborhood shows how urban development has been used to harm urban residents and how community resilience is the key to sustainable communities for all.

Single Room Occupancy (SRO) Hotels

Single Room Occupancy (SROs) are hotels offering small, minimally furnished rooms for daily, weekly, or monthly rates. Rooms do not require a lease, since these are technically hotels, but for many patrons this is their primary residence (Guevarra & Reddy, Resisting Urban Removal, 2017). In Chicago, these started to appear in the late 1800's (Chicago Historical Society, 2004). Rooms were typically partitioned into cubicles from larger units. It was common to have chicken wire sealing off the ceiling, coining the nickname "cage hotels" (Chicago Historical

Society, 2004). SROs of even lesser quality were dormitories, large floors with open bunks, and one paid nightly for a bed (Chicago Historical Society, 2004). Heat, lighting, and ventilation were of poor quality, and sanitary conditions were often considered terrible, as some rooms had up to 200 beds on a floor (Chicago Historical Society, 2004).

SROs today have better conditions than in years past. They offer access to full utilities (electricity, heat, internet, and bathrooms), and while most offer private rooms, most facilities are shared (Guevarra & Reddy, Resisting Urban Removal, 2017). Some offer laundry facilities and mailing addresses for their residents. However, the quality of SROs is often considered poor for today's living standards: for-profit, low-income housing needs more resources to ensure proper maintenance. They are often the housing of “first step” and “last resort”: they provide accessible housing for those transiting from a shelter or complete homelessness. SROs do not have the same restrictions on accessibility or night limits some homeless shelters have, provided one can pay their rent.

A History of Uptown

Uptown’s Luxury Hotels

A mixture of undeveloped land, lakefront proximity, and access to various transportation lines caused Uptown to boom in the early 1910s (Commission on Chicago Landmarks, 2016). The area drew particular attention from wealthy developers, and the area soon became littered with beach resorts, department stores, and dance halls. The name “Uptown” comes from a marketing campaign from department store mogul Loren Miller, who wanted to compare the Loop to the neighborhood that housed his new store. If there was a “downtown” shopping district, this was now an “uptown” one (Commission on Chicago Landmarks, 2016). The opening of Essanay Movies Studio and the Uptown Theater movie palace cemented the neighborhood as a playground for the rich and famous (Commission on Chicago Landmarks, 2016). This created a demand for luxury residential hotels for wealthy residents to call home, and gorgeous art-deco buildings like the Wilton, New Lawrence, and Somerset Hotels were erected in the neighborhood in the 1920s (Chicago Historical Society, 2004).

While demand for luxury housing dwindled during the Great Depression, demand for affordable housing skyrocketed as transient workers from across the country came to Chicago looking for jobs (Guevarra & Reddy, Resisting Urban Removal, 2017). The owners of luxury hotels began to partition their rooms into SRO units to service this new market. During WW2, Uptown's nightlight scene received a slight surge in popularity: sailors and soldiers from Fort Sheridan and the Great Lakes Naval Station visited on the weekend, taking advantage of the smaller, cheaper apartments (Commission on Chicago Landmarks, 2016). However, the housing trends of the 1940s – 1950 ended Uptown's reputation as a luxury district: white flight and suburbanization removed wealth from cities (Guevarra & Reddy, Resisting Urban Removal, 2017). This permanently ended the construction of new hotels, and SRO partitioning became the dominant trend (Guevarra & Reddy, Resisting Urban Removal, 2017). This led to Uptown having the highest number of SROs in Chicago (Fulgham & Hoereth, 2020).

Community Organizing vs Urban Renewal

As the wealthy left the neighborhood, the rest of the world came to Uptown. Global economic conditions of the 1940s – 1960s caused the mass migration of poor people from diverse backgrounds to urban centers (Guevarra & Reddy, Resisting Urban Removal, 2017). Black Americans from the South, Native Americans from the Midwest, Puerto Ricans from their home island, and poor whites from Appalachia flocked to Chicago looking for a better life (Guevarra & Reddy, Resisting Urban Removal, 2017). These groups were soon joined by immigrants from Asia who were displaced by the war in Vietnam. The high amount of affordable housing in Uptown made it a natural landing place for these new Chicagoans, and many found homes in the SROs (Guevarra & Reddy, Resisting Urban Removal, 2017).

Housing conditions in Uptown were less than ideal. The owners of SRO buildings had little financial incentive to provide a secure or comfortable living environment for residents living off welfare or a minimum wage income (Guevarra & Reddy, Resisting Urban Removal, 2017). The neighborhood was a shadow of its former glory: unsanitary housing conditions, a concentration of poverty, and a lack of community amenities led Uptown's "slums" to gain infamy through Chicago (Guevarra & Reddy, Resisting Urban Removal, 2017). However, the residents of Uptown would not accept these inhumane conditions.

As residents of vastly different cultural backgrounds were living near each other, they discovered they were all affected by poverty and a lack of resources (Guevarra & Reddy, Revolutionary Grease: The Rainbow Coalition, 2017). The neighborhood became an epicenter of multi-racial, class-based activism, and groups like the Intercommunal Survival Community, Jobs Or Income Now, and Students for a Democratic Society soon became a noticeable presence in Uptown. One of the most potent political forces to originate in Uptown was the Young Patriots: a former gang of white Appalachian migrants who turned into an anti-racist, socialist political group that joined with the Black Panthers and Young Lords to create the Rainbow Coalition (Guevarra & Reddy, Revolutionary Grease: The Rainbow Coalition, 2017).

These Uptown residents' organizations were the most vital force advocating for better living conditions, jobs, and resources for the community. They pressured landlords to improve housing conditions, pressured welfare offices to stop discriminatory practices, and operated health clinics and food-buying co-ops (Guevarra & Reddy, Revolutionary Grease: The Rainbow Coalition, 2017). The strength of the community activists is one of the reasons urban displacements were contested in Uptown. In the 1970s, city governments tied with business interests were looking to tear down poorer sections of cities and replace them with private developments.

This concept thrilled the landlords and business interests in Uptown, who were eager to sell off their slums and replace their current tenants with a wealthy white demographic (Guevarra & Reddy, Resisting Urban Removal, 2017). The SRO hotels were a key target for this "renewal." The developer Bill Thompson, Mayor J. Daley's ex-son-in-law, set his sights in Uptown, yet community resistance was able to stop most of these redevelopments (Guevarra & Reddy, Resisting Urban Removal, 2017). In the 1980s, community groups like ONE Northside and Voice of the People collaborated with tenants in subsidized HUD buildings. In a time when affordable housing was disappearing nationwide, these tenants were able to push out racist landlords and get non-profits to acquire and maintain their buildings (Guevarra & Reddy, Resisting Urban Removal, 2017). It was a living example of development without displacement.

Status of SROs Today

Between the 1990s and today, most of the SROs in Uptown have been redeveloped despite community resistance (Guevarra & Reddy, Resisting Urban Removal, 2017). The Lawernce Hotel and Wilson Men's Hotel were former Uptown SROs that are now privately owned apartments (Guevarra & Reddy, Resisting Urban Removal, 2017). The residents of this hotel usually have no other housing options: one resident of the Wilson Men's Hotel was permanently displaced when the SRO was bought by a luxury developer (Ballew, 2019).

There was an attempt to address this problem when the Chicago City Council passed the 2014 SRO Preservation Ordinance with a 49 – 1 vote (Fulgham & Hoereth, 2020). The ordinance created an Improvement and Stabilization program that would give loans and tax credits to SRO owners. The ordinance required SRO sellers to have a 6-month priority period where only affordable housing developers could purchase the SRO before private developers could bid on the building (Fulgham & Hoereth, 2020). The ordinance also required all developers to ensure any displaced residents were relocated to affordable housing before the sale of the SRO was complete (Fulgham & Hoereth, 2020).

However, this has not had the intended effect: 37% of operating SROs have closed in Chicago since the ordinance was passed (Fulgham & Hoereth, 2020). Uptown saw 60% of its SROs close between 2005 – 2019, and all the SROs sold in Uptown went to market-rate developers (Fulgham & Hoereth, 2020). City Pads, who bought the Wilsons Men Hotel, did not follow the resident resettlement policy (Fulgham & Hoereth, 2020). While SROs continue to disappear in Uptown, two of the remaining active SROs are in my research area: the Northmere SRO and the Aragon Arms Hotel. Ironically, they are a four-minute walk away from a former luxury hotel turned market-rate apartment, the Somerset Place Apartments. The battle for affordable housing continues in Uptown, which is present in two buildings across the street from each other.

Differences in Housing Options

Located in the High-Income block group, The Somerset Hotel at 5009 N. Sheridan was an eight-story luxury apartment hotel built in the early 1920s. Located less than a mile from the shores of Lake Michigan, the hotel was marketed as both an "exclusive summer resort" and a year-round residential home (Newman, 2004). The hotel contained 441 fully furnished rooms within 205 suites, with suites ranging from one to four bedrooms. All rooms were furnished entirely, with the smallest apartments offering a living room, dressing room, and private bath. The larger apartments had all the amenities of the smaller ones but included a sun parlor, dining room, and kitchenette (Newman, 2004). The hotel offered guests a rooftop promenade, a full-service dining room, and twice-weekly dinner dances. Rent ranged from $100 - $400 a month

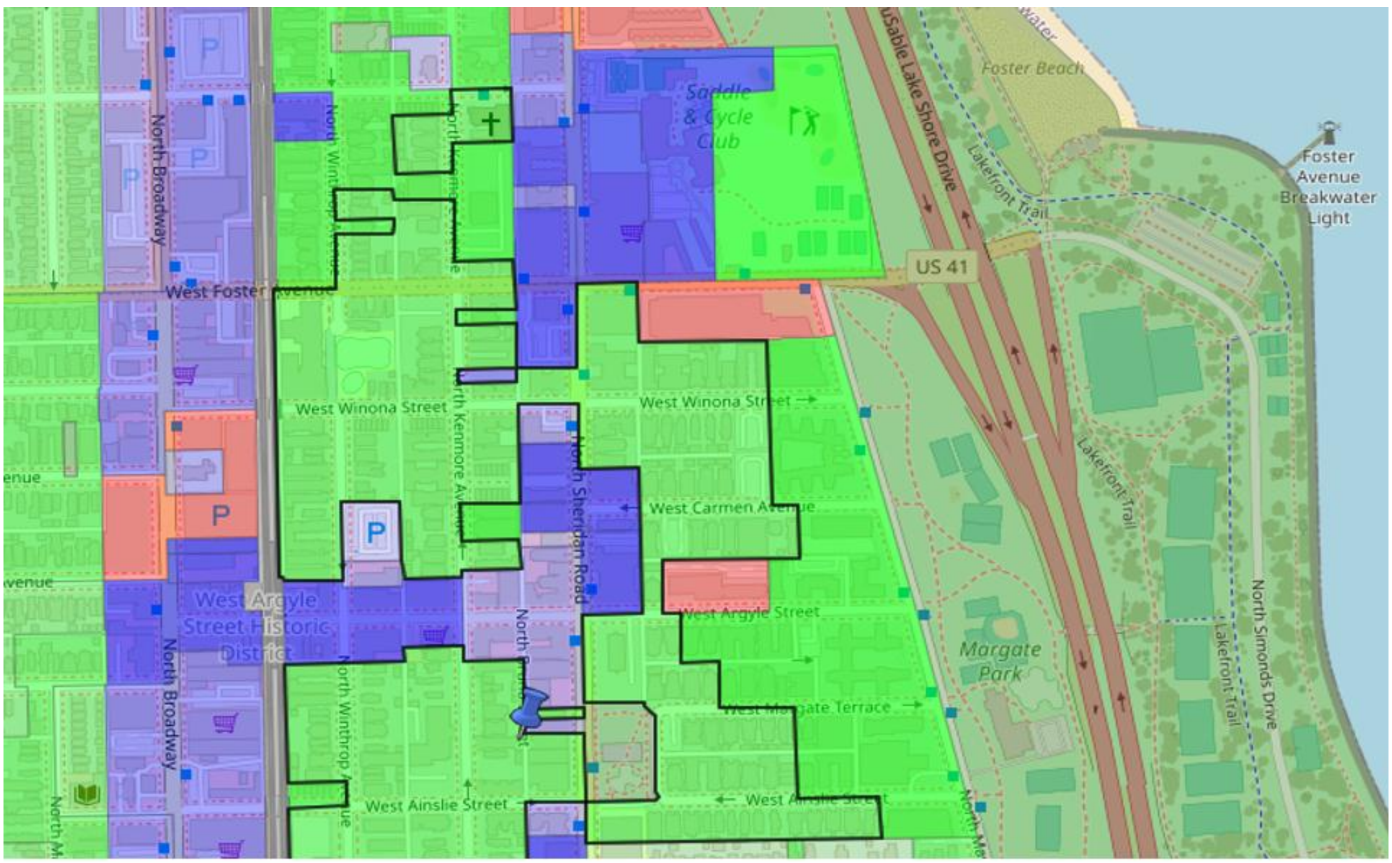
($1,700 - $7,600 in 2023 dollars) and included electricity, gas, ice, laundry, and maid service (Newman, 2004).

The hotel survived the Great Depression, but its glamor began to fade in the 1950s. In 1969, the owners applied for a zoning variation to convert the hotel to an assisted living facility (Newman, 2004) and the hotel reopened as the Somerset House, offering 720 beds for new residents. Somerset operated as a sheltered care home until 2010. It reopened as the Somerset Place Apartments in 2014, and the building was added to the National Register of Historic Places during additional renovations (Newman, 2004). It offers studio, 1-bedroom, and 2-bedroom apartments for rent. Monthly rent for a studio range between $1,400 - $1,900, and 1- and 2-bedrooms range between $1,800 - $2,500.

The Aragon Arms Hotel, located at 4914 N. Kenmore in the SRO block group, is one of the few remaining SROs still operating in Uptown. The hotel does not have a website, and while they do have a phone number listed on their Google Maps page, no one picked up the phone after I called ten times. I was only able to get information about the Aragon by visiting in person, where I was able to speak with Micheal, the clerk working the front desk at the time (he asked for his last name not to be included). The Aragon offers three types of rooms: a private studio, a private room with a shared bathroom with one other person, and a private bed with a communal bathroom and facilities (Micheal, 2024). A studio rents for $680 a month and includes a gas stove and refrigerator. The shared-bathroom unit rents for $640 a month, and the communal option rents for $600 a month. All rents include utilities (water, gas, internet, cable), but furniture rental costs an additional $60 a month (Micheal, 2024). Rent can be paid in daily, weekly, or monthly installments, and all rent must be paid in money orders. Coin-operated laundry is available onsite for all residents (Micheal, 2024).

Micheal, who also lives in an SRO in Edgewater, has worked for the Aragon Arms for two years. Working at the SRO has been difficult at times: there was a shooting outside on the street within the two months he first started working there (Micheal, 2024). The city has been doing construction in the area, and once the construction abruptly shut off water in the hotel for 2 ½ days. When the water was restored, the water pressure caused damage to Aragon's boiler: a replacement one cost $30,000 (Micheal, 2024). Insurance covered most of the cost, but Micheal believes some costs were passed down to the hotel's residents. Micheal believes the community wants the SRO gone from the neighborhood: non-SRO residents have told him they believe the hotels to be a crime hub (Micheal, 2024). Micheal has also seen other SROs close recently: there used to be another SRO across the street from the one he lives in, but in 2022, the owner sold the building to developers and paid the current tenants to leave (Micheal, 2024).

Land Use Map



Zoning type (what's that?)

- Residential
- Commercial
- Industrial
- Planned Development
- Transportation
- Parks and Open Space

Land Use & Assets

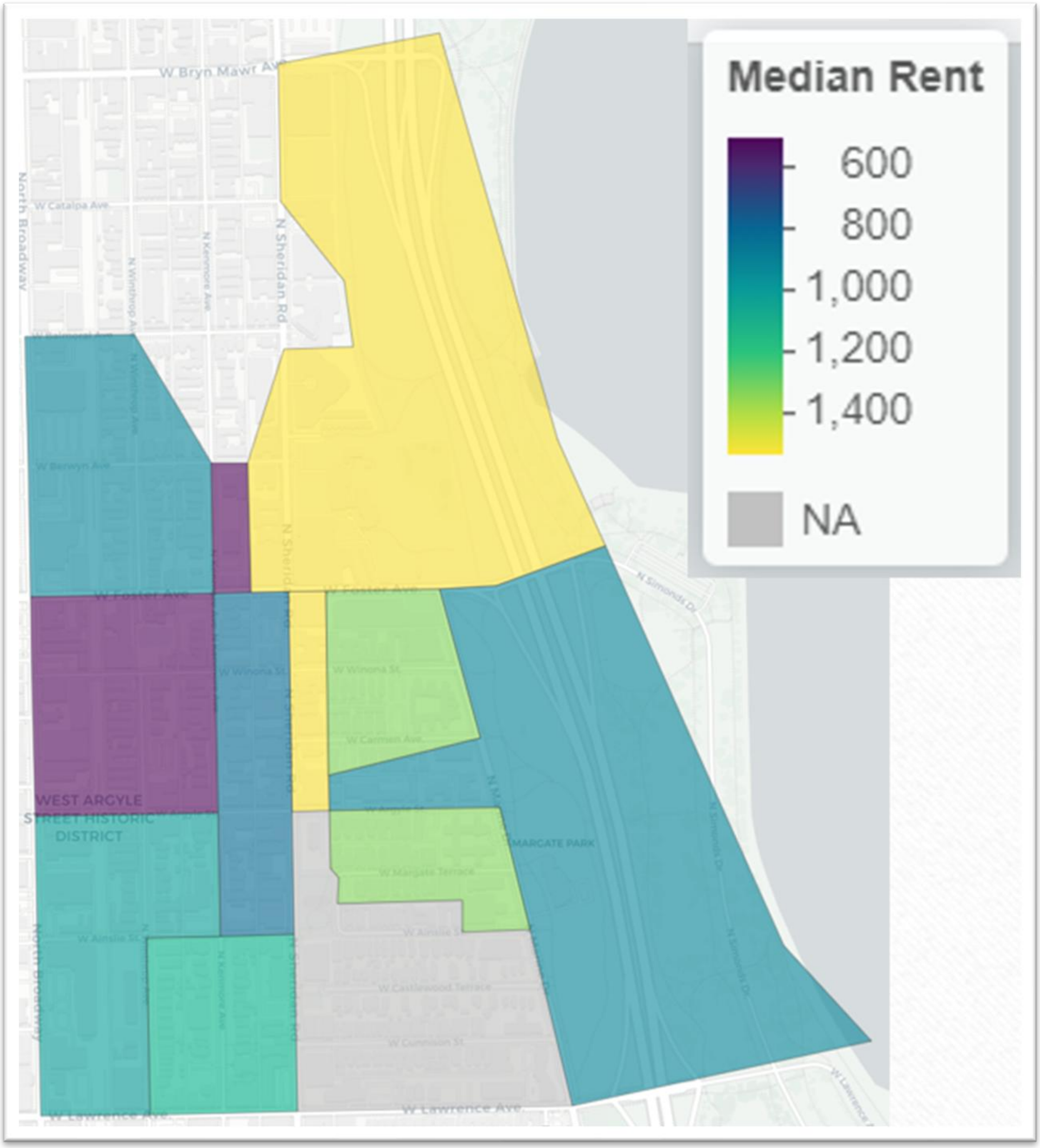
This section of Uptown is a dense, mixed-use, transit-oriented neighborhood. Most residential zoning is R-4 or higher: the smallest maximum for any residential building in this area is 38ft, and the smallest maximum floor-area ratio is 1.2 (Eder, Velez, & O'Conner, n.d.). The residential area near the lakefront is RM-6.5, with no maximum height and a floor-area ratio of 6.6 (Eder, Velez, & O'Conner, n.d.). The commercial zoning areas are B3-2 and B1-5, Community and Neighborhood Shopping Districts that allow retail and large storefronts on major and low-traffic streets (Eder, Velez, & O'Conner, n.d.). These commercial districts allow for apartments above the first floor, while the car-oriented commercial district (C2-5) surrounding Broadway does not (Eder, Velez, & O'Conner, n.d.). The planned developments in the area are tall, dense senior residential facilities (Eder, Velez, & O'Conner, n.d.). There are three retirement communities in this area: Kenmore Plaza, the Self-Help House, and the Admiral on the Lake.

This area is near multiple public transit options. It is within a ten-minute walk of three Red Line Stops: the Lawrence, Argyle, and Berwyn stations. It is also within a ten-minute walk of eight bus routes: the 36, 81, 92, 136, 146, 147, 148, and 151. There are multiple Divvy stops within this same walking distance, with stations placed along Sheridan, Broadway, Foster, and Marine Drive (Eder, Velez, & O'Conner, n.d.). All these factors, combined with access to Lake Shore Drive via Foster Avenue, allow for easy access to Lakeview, the Loop, and even Evanston via the El.

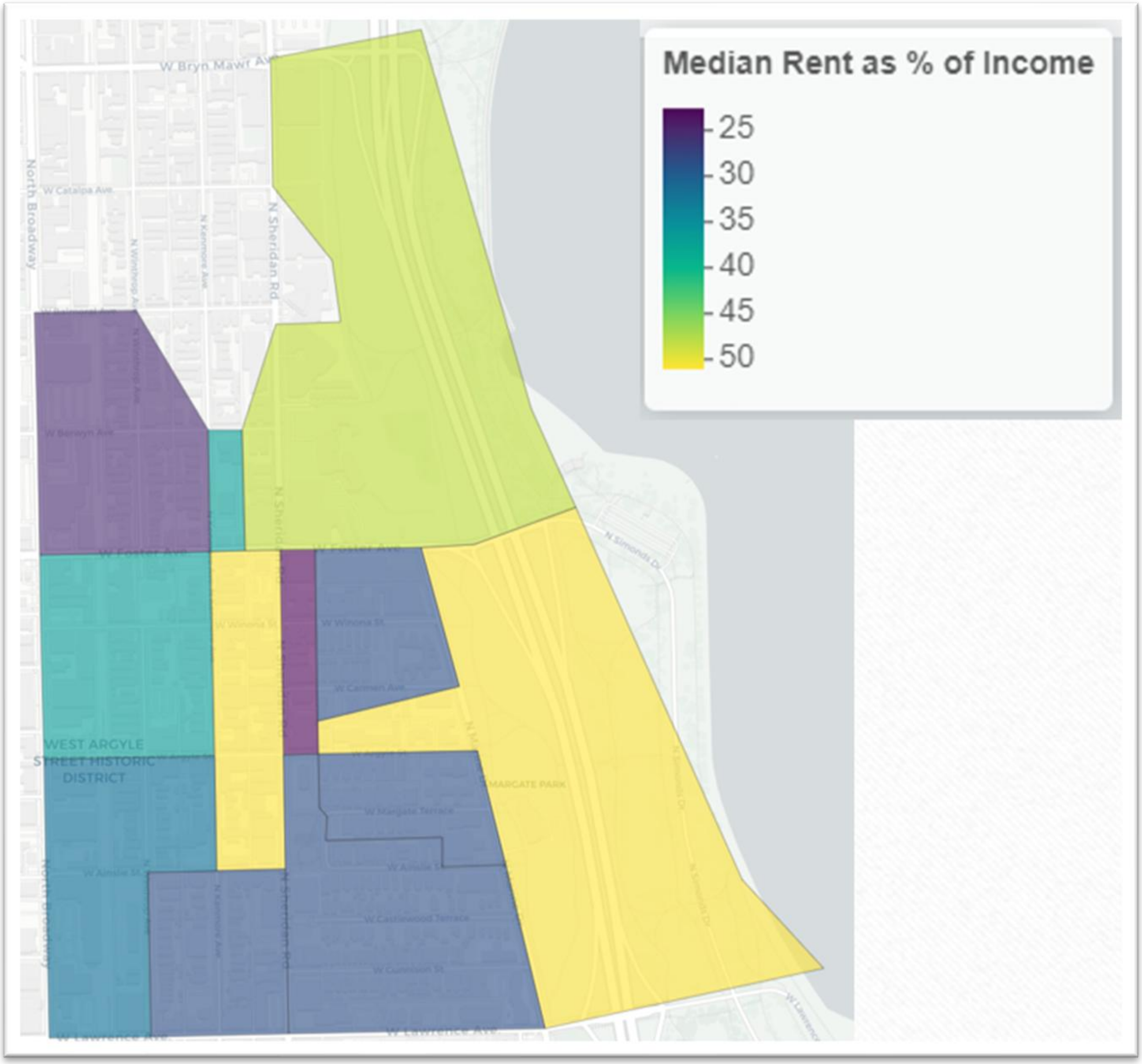
The neighborhood is also within proximity to various cultural assets. Foster Beach and the lakefront athletic fields are within walking distance, as well as Buttercup and Margate Park. The Argyle Shopping District (Asia on Argyle) and the Saddle & Cycle Country Club are in the area. This neighborhood has easy access to the Uptown Square entertainment district, as the Riveria Theater, Green Mill, and Aragon Ballroom are next to the Lawernce Red Line stop. These entertainment districts and cultural neighborhoods are also commercially zoned, allowing bars and restaurants to be scattered throughout the neighborhood.

Median Rent & Housing Costs, Income & Poverty Data

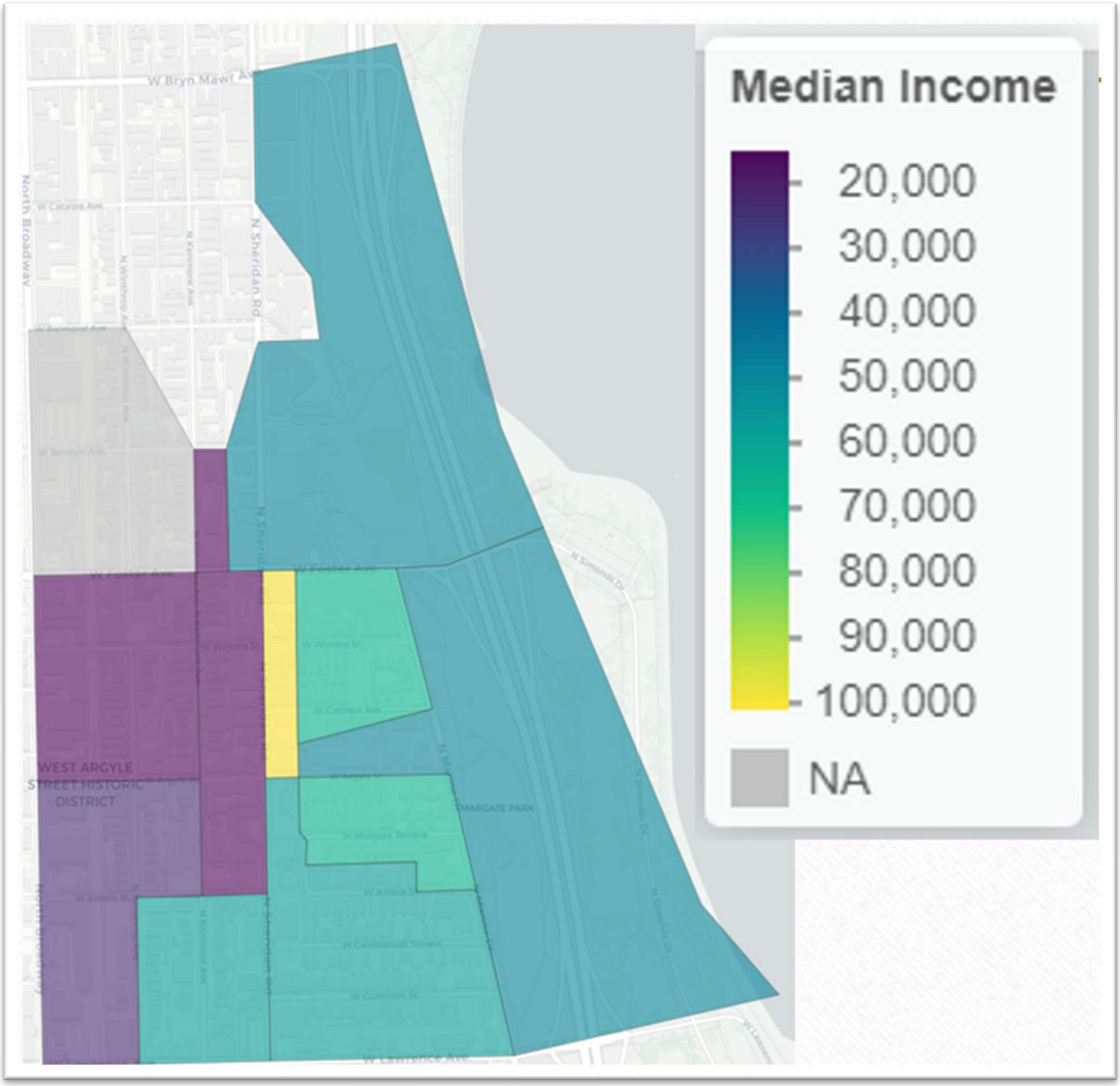
Median Rent Map



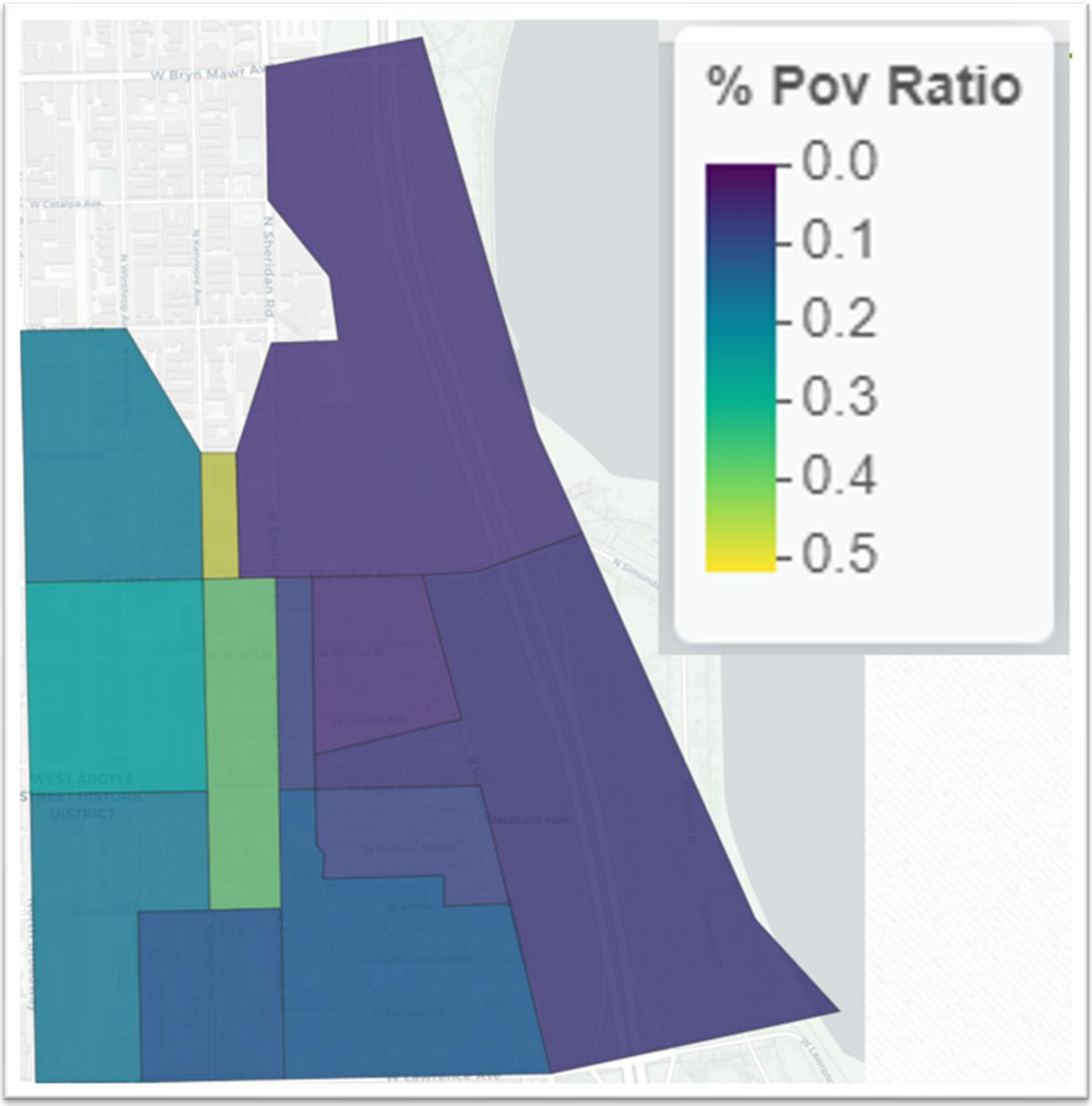
Median Rent as Percentage of Income



Median Income Map



Map Showing the Percentage of the Population Living with an Income at or Below the Poverty Line



Median Rent & Housing Costs, Income & Poverty Data

There are stark differences in rents throughout the researched area. The most prominent difference is between the SRO block group and the High-Income block group: the median rent is $804 and $1,531 monthly, a difference of $727. This makes sense, considering the different types of housing in each block group. Rent prices in the area follow a pattern: the closer to the lake, the higher the rent. Three of the four block groups closest to the lake have a median rent of $1,300 or higher. The one outlier has a rent of $907, but that block group is mapped around a retirement home. The block groups on the west side of the map have a lower rent, ranging from $500 - $1168. The two purple block groups, indicating a rent in the $500s, have interesting makeup. The smaller purple block group only has two buildings: a church and a retirement home. The other has a wide variety of buildings: a public school, public housing and affordable housing, and market-rate apartments.

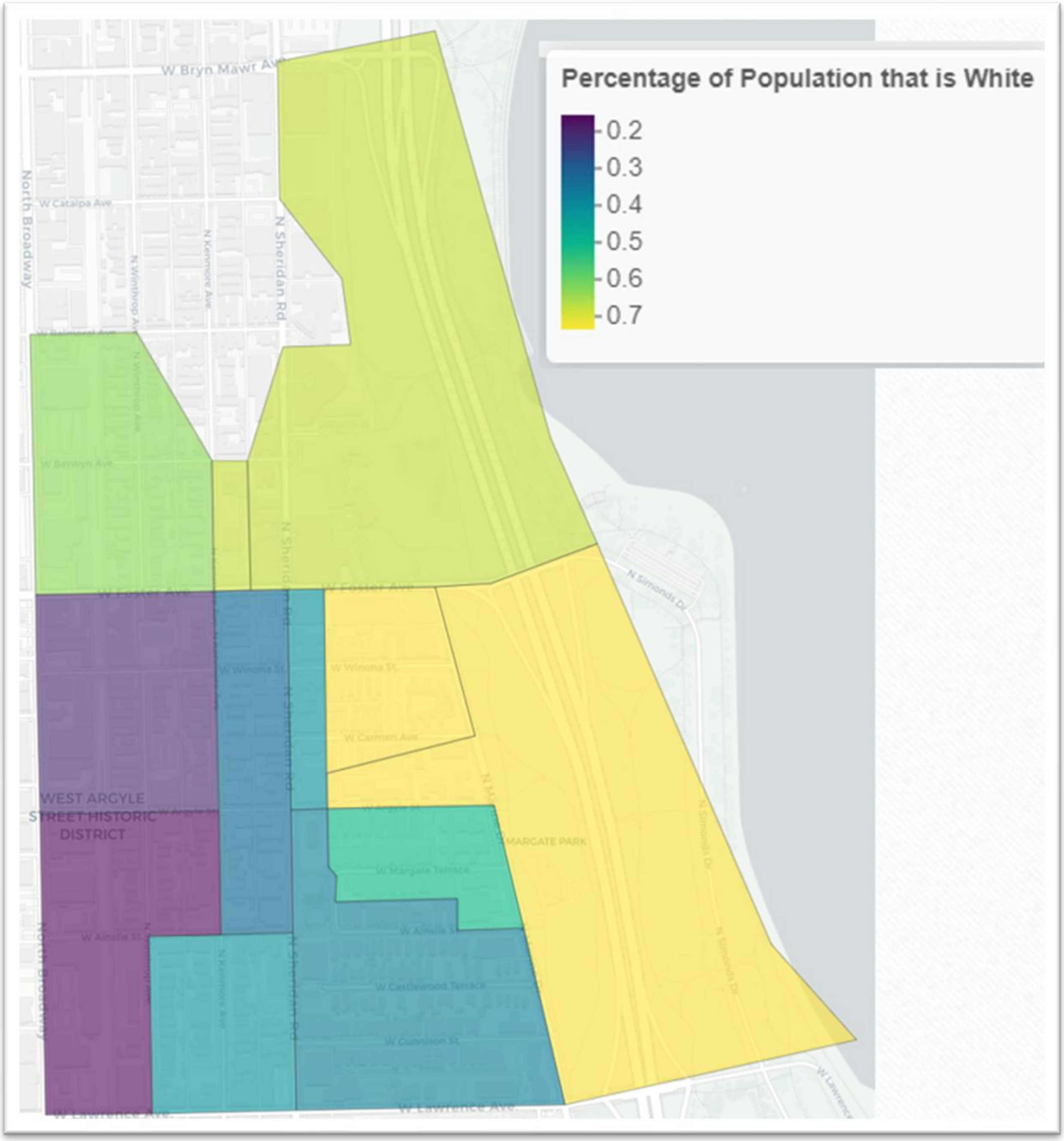
The map showing the median rent as a percentage of income shows an interesting inverse between the SRO and High-Income group: while the median rent is lower in the SRO block group, it is a drastically higher percentage of the resident's income. The SRO block group's rent is 51% of income, while the High-Income block group's rent is only 22.7% of income, a difference of almost 30%. The blocks in Margate Park west of Sheridan all hover around 28% of rent to income, except for the two block groups closest to the lake. The two-block groups have retirement homes (which could affect how income is measured) and luxury beachfront apartments, which have the highest median rents in the area. The block groups with the lowest median rents in the area still spend around 35% of their income on rent. Affordable housing advocates consider those spending 30% or more of their monthly income on housing costs to be rent-burdened, meaning that 4 out of the 12 block groups in this neighborhood are rent-burdened (Loury, 2024).

The median income map shows that the High-Income block group is an outlier. Its median income is $100,563, and the second-highest income in the area is $68,488. The blocks east of Sheridan have a median income ranging from $45,774 - $68,488, while the blocks east of Sheridan are much poorer. Except for one block group with a median income of $60,683, the median income below ranges from $15,281 to $24,599. The map showing the percentage of the population living with an income at or below the poverty line reinforces these findings. There is a correlation between a higher median income in a block group and a lower percentage of the population living below the poverty line. The SRO block group has 41.2% of its population living at or below the poverty line, while the Higher-Income group only has 3.7% of its population facing poverty.

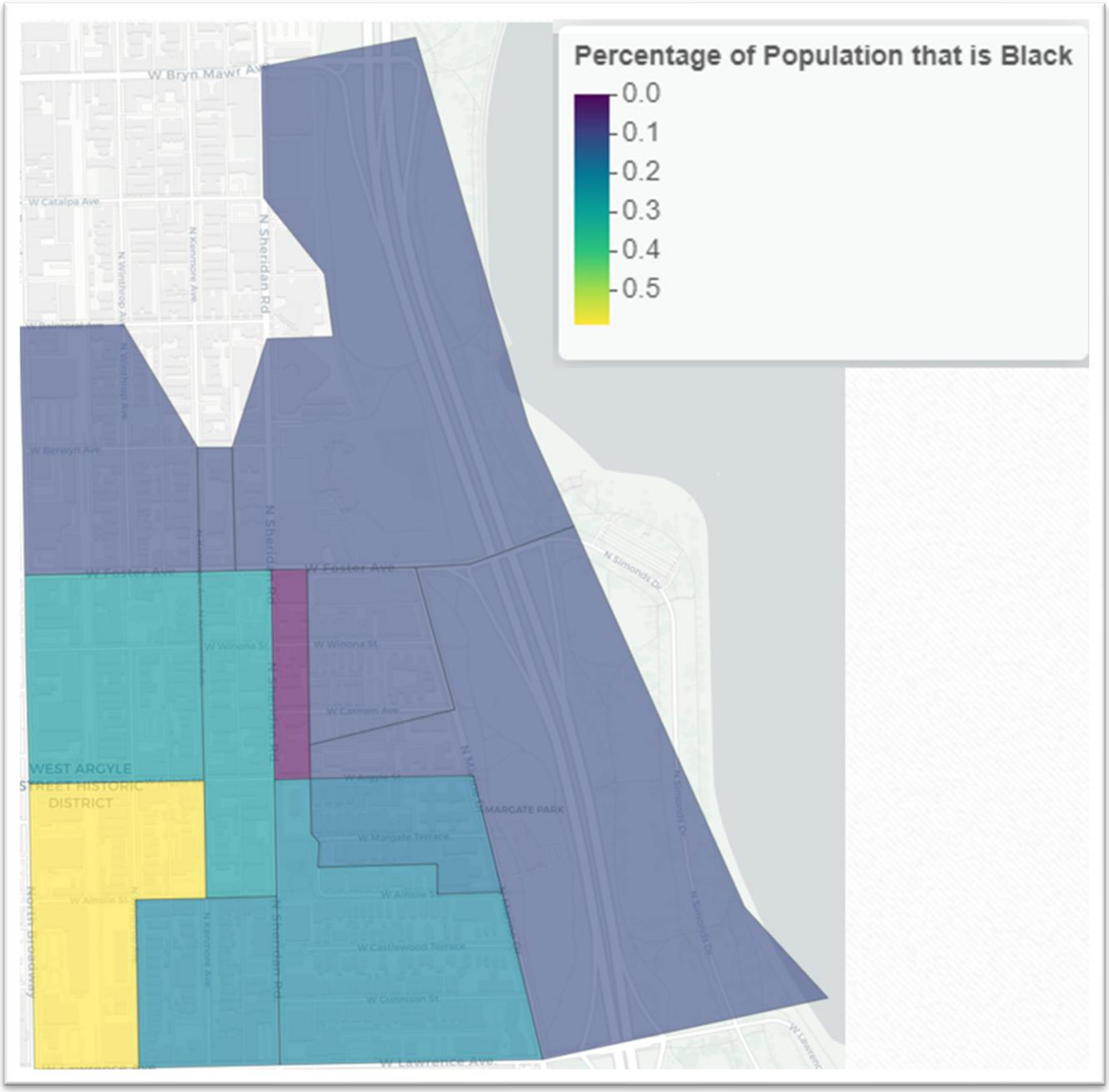
Race Demographics

Half of the block groups in the area are majority white, and one-third of the block groups have white people, who make up 66% or more of the population. There is only one block group with a majority Black population, with a 58% majority, despite the area including the "Asia on Argyle" district, people of Asian descent or not more than 22% of any block group. People of Hispanic or Latino descent are present most in the block groups with the highest and lowest incomes. The SRO block group's population is diverse: its population is 32% White, 24.6% Black, and 29% of Hispanic or Laino descent, but only 7.8% of Asian descent. The High-Income block group's population is 44.3% White, 14% of Asian descent, and 41.6% of Hispanic or Latino descent. According to the Census data, no Black people are living in the High-Income block group. There is a negative correlation between whiteness and poverty within the block groups: the more significant the White population of a block group is, the lower percentage of their population is living at or below the poverty line.

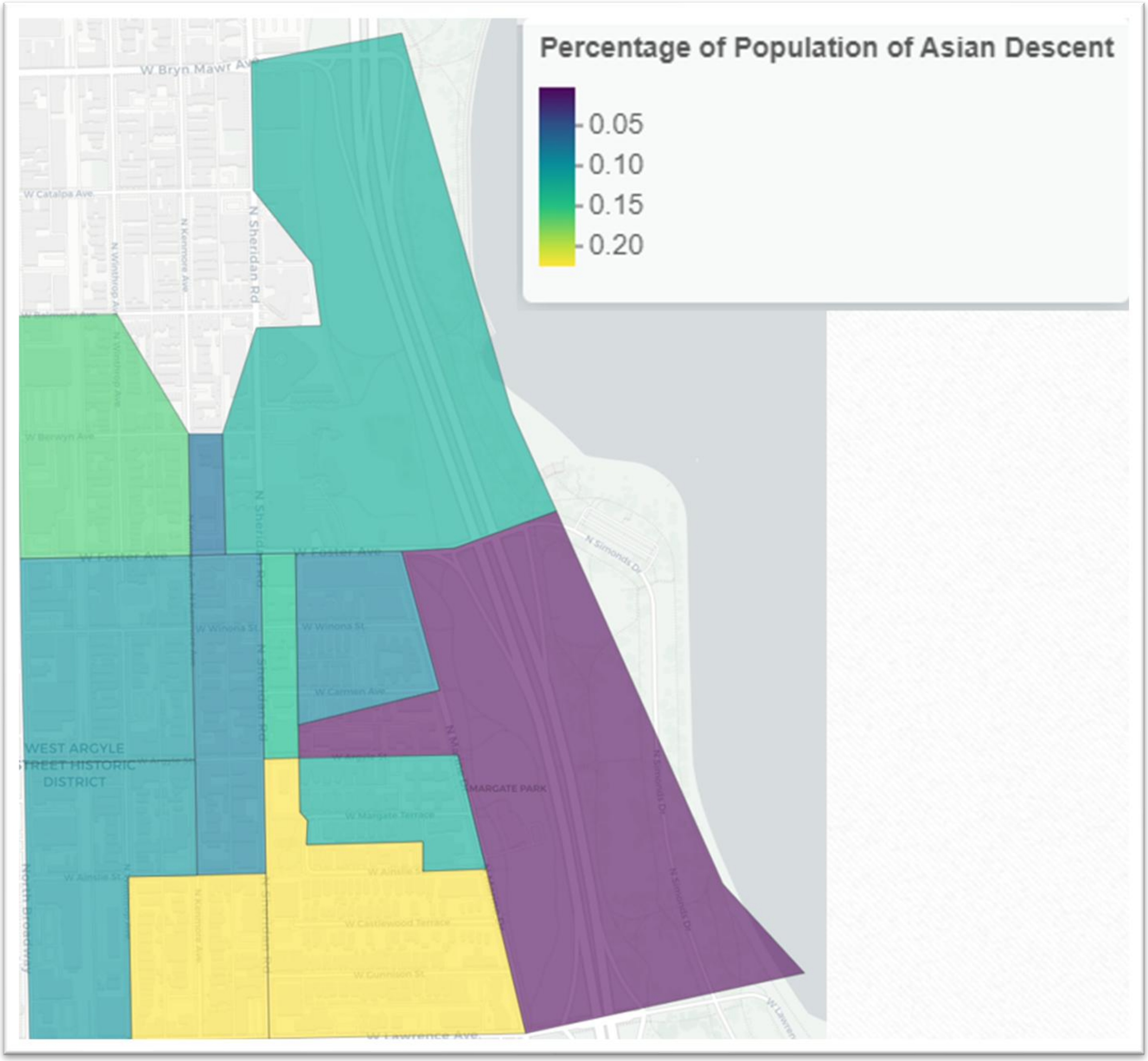
Map of the Population that is White



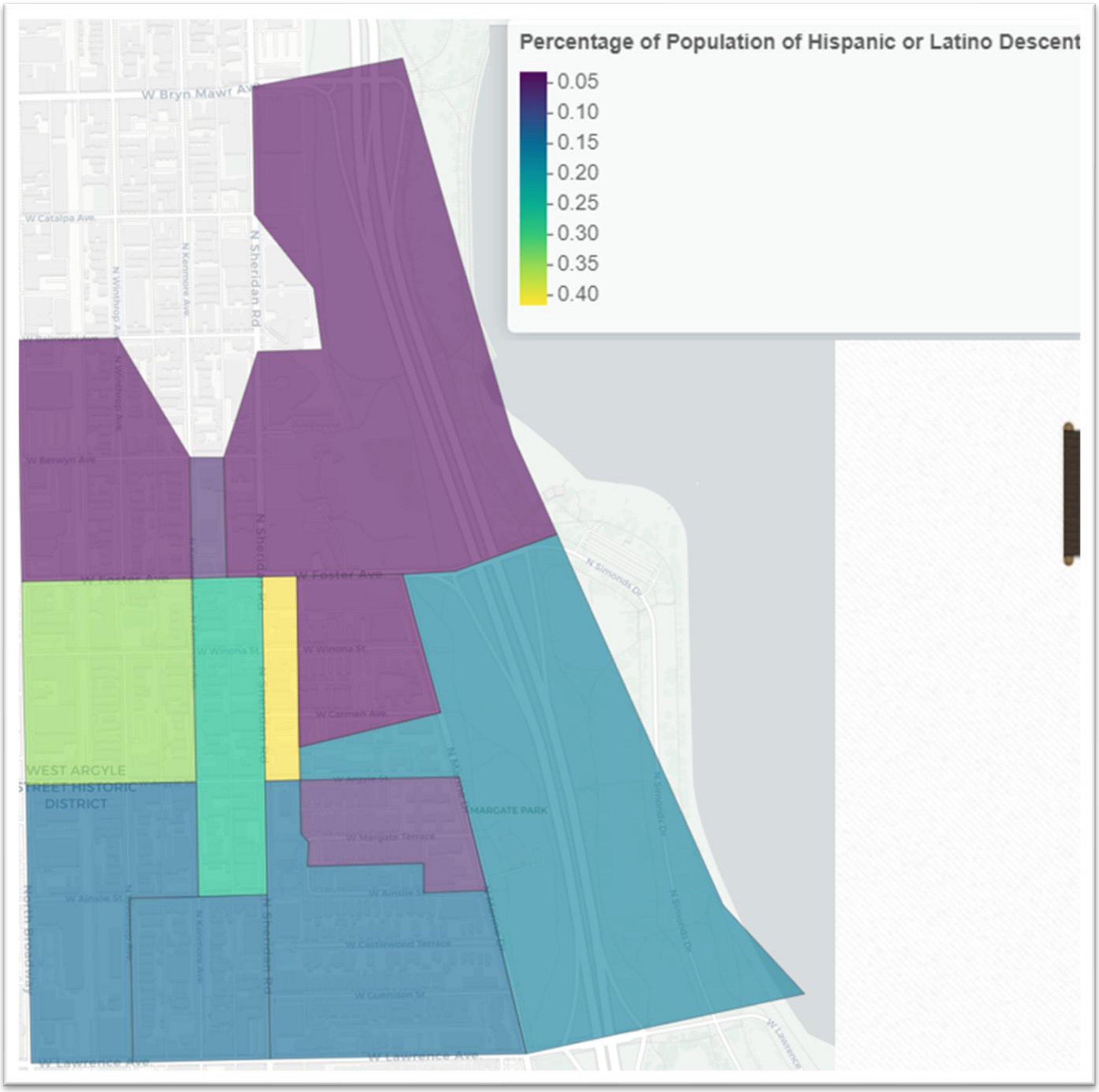
Map of the Population that is Black



Map of the Population that is of Asian Descent



Map of the Population that is of Hispanics or Latino Descent



The Solution: Public Money Should Fund Existing Community Work

Housing is becoming unsustainable in Uptown as private developers purchase affordable housing units and increase rents, displacing residents and fueling the housing crisis. This also threatens Uptown's diverse legacy, as poorer residents of color are typically replaced with a whiter, wealthier demographic: the classic threat of gentrification. However, the key to Uptown's sustainable future is found in its past: the neighborhood's history of community organizing lives on today, with various non-profits carrying on the legacy of mutual aid that was forged in the 1970s.

Voice of the People is an affordable housing developer that builds and manages affordable housing, provides economic development services to its residents, and offers networking services for owners and developers looking to create affordable housing in Uptown (Voice of the People, 2024). Voice currently co-owns and operates a portfolio of 14 buildings, which contains a total of 214 affordable units (Voice of the People, 2024). Their Property Management staff works directly with building residents to manage housing upgrades, and residents also provide input on future housing projects (Voice of the People, 2024). Their Resident Support Services offer case management programs for their residents. These programs include an individualized needs assessment, referrals to financial programs and services, and transitional coaching to prepare and assist residents when they decide to leave Voice-owned housing (Voice of the People, 2024). They also provide property management workshops to train their residents in self-managed housing practices (Voice of the People, 2024).

Voice is also planning a larger affordable housing project: Diversity Land Trust (Voice of the People, 2024). This is a community land trust that is dedicated to protecting Uptown's diversity and ensuring permanent affordable housing options for property owners and residents. Voice plans to seed the trust with three of its properties and plans to include rental and owner-occupied housing options incorporated in a shared-equity model (Voice of the People, 2024). Planned benefits to members include property tax relief, property management technical assistance, preferred access to subsidies, and government financing. They plan to expand the trust with the help of public officials, asset managers, and other housing owners in the city (Voice of the People, 2024).

Sarah’s Circle is a non-profit dedicated to ending homelessness for women in Chicago (Sarah's Circle, 2024). While they operate in multiple locations in Chicago, their Daytime Support Center is in Uptown at 4848 N Sheridan, a few blocks south of the SRO block group. The Daytime Support Center offers meals, showers, laundries, and mailing addresses for women experiencing homelessness (Sarah's Circle, 2024). The building also offers a computer lab, free workshops in financial literacy and legal services, and the opportunity to meet with a case manager (Sarah's Circle, 2024). Sarah's Circle operates an Interim Housing Program via a 50-bed shelter that is open every day of the year. They are also affordable housing managers operating a portfolio of 113 units (Sarah's Circle, 2024). Sarah’s Circle only offers services to women, as women experiencing homelessness face a unique intersection of problems, and Sarah’s staff are trained with a trauma-based approach (Sarah's Circle, 2024).

Community-focused non-profits are leading the fight against homelessness in Uptown by building affordable housing and providing housing services for those without shelter. However, most non-profits have a shared problem: a need for more funds. While both Voice and Sarah's Circle have their development program, public money should be utilized to fund the work they are already doing rather than the city spearheading projects without community involvement.

City-backed development projects are part of the reason affordable housing has disappeared in Uptown, and the city needs to earn the community's trust. Funding existing community organizations is a step in the right direction. Luckily, there is a new opportunity to do this: as of February 19th, 2024, Mayor Johnson's office released their Housing and Economic Development Bond Allocation Plan for 2024 – 2028. This plan includes an investment of $625 million for affordable housing, home ownership, and homelessness prevention over the next five years (City of Chicago, 2024, p. 4).

This plan includes $20-30 million for SRO preservation (City of Chicago, 2024, p. 21). The city will partner with the Community Investment Corporation to create an SRO Loan Fund: an investment and refinance pool for existing and potential owners of SRO buildings. The fund is designed to improve the financial viability of SROs by reducing debt and operating costs for owners, who then will ideally be able to pass those savings onto tenants in the form of lower rents (City of Chicago, 2024, p. 21). This plan is admirable, but it does not go far enough. SROs in Uptown are in multi-unit buildings in a transit-oriented neighborhood near the lakefront: prime real estate for private developers. While this SRO Loan Fund is designed to make operating an SRO more viable for owners, it may end up being more profitable for SRO owners to sell to a private developer.

The 2014 SRO Preservation Ordinance has not stopped the sale of SRO to market-rate housing, and $30 million over five years may not be enough to stop this trend unless that money is prioritized for organizations that are dedicated to preserving affordable housing. The SRO Loan Fund should be dedicated to non-profit developers who wish to add SROs to their portfolio. For example, if Voice of the People wished to purchase the Aragon Arms Hotel, this loan pool could help with the purchase, give favorable loan conditions, and help fund the rehabilitation of Aragon to improve living conditions. Voice would be able to add Aragon to its future land trust, ensuring the building stays affordable for future generations. There is a proven track record of the private market failing SRO residents in Uptown: SROs must be taken off the market to ensure their affordability.

This same principle should be applied to the $125 -$145 million allocated to down payment assistance, home repair, and homeowner support (City of Chicago, 2024, p. 17). This money is allocated to help income-eligible homeowners with down payments, closing costs, inspection costs, and appraisal gaps (City of Chicago, 2024, p. 17). Bond funds will also be available for community-based developers to build new single-family homes on vacant City-owned land (City of Chicago, 2024, p. 17). This money should not just be reserved for individuals but also for community organizations like Voice, which have plans to build community wealth through home ownership. This type of funding will help reduce the cost of adding new buildings to their portfolio, which will expand the resources of the proposed land trust. Bond money should also not be restricted to new single-family construction but allow for multi-family construction on vacant lots or rehabilitation of existing multi-unit buildings.

Finally, public money should be used to support organizations doing homelessness prevention. Voice and Sarah's Circle have existing relationships in the Uptown community and know about what resources are needed in the area. The most significant opportunity for this funding will come from the potential Bring Chicago Home referendum, which is a proposed increase in the real estate transfer tax to help fund homelessness prevention (Weinberg & Woelfel, 2024). Supporters of this plan estimate that it will raise $100 million annually, and this money can be used for rental subsidies, mental health services, job training, and other wraparound services. Voice and Sarah's Circle offer these types of services already; funding these existing programs will be an effective use of potential funds. Also, SRO residents are eligible for City rent subsidies (Department of Family & Support Services, 2024). Rent assistance for residents will help shed economic burdens for those facing multiple hardships.

Measures of Success or Failure

These City programs have the potential to build community-controlled wealth. Public money could help finance a land trust's purchase and rehabilitation of an SRO, protecting it from market-rate developers. Existing outreach programs will require extra funding to support the SRO residents while they are under construction. The SRO residents will have access to rent subsidies, which will simultaneously help residents with economic mobility and give the land trust and non-profit developer more economic support. The outreach programs will have additional resources for case management and help residents transition to their own permanent, affordable housing, which public funds and non-profit developers provide.

However, this is just an idea: no dream survives intact when it becomes reality. I have advocated for community non-profits over city departments to take the lead in Uptown's housing preservation, but no organization is immune from mismanagement or corruption. Any organization receiving public money must provide complete transparency over the funded projects and allow City staff members to audit the project process. If an NGO abuses taxpayer money, it may prevent support for public funding for future projects.

Thankfully, it will be simple to measure SRO preservation effectiveness. The primary measure will be to track how many remaining SROs are closed: the ideal number is zero. SRO ownership status must be tracked as well, as this plan recommends that SROs be transferred into non-profit hands. If any SRO is bought by a non-profit, building maintenance, operations, and resident quality of life must be tracked. A non-profit may be dedicated to quality housing, but one cannot assume that mission translates into competent management.

Other community housing programs must also be operational. Voice of the People's Diversity Land Trust must be out of the planning phase and start to be implemented so their affordability strategy can begin to be evaluated. They must prove they have the knowledge and ability to provide comfortable and safe affordable housing to the people of Uptown, and they must be able to have the skills to manage an increased housing portfolio. While the goal is to expand affordable housing in the area, the groups cannot expand so fast that the quality of housing suffers.

SRO and homelessness shelter residents' economic mobility must be tracked. The goal of outreach work and housing stewardship is to have people transition to permanent and secure housing. Case managers and social workers must share data measuring the effectiveness of their work to see if current tactics to end homelessness are working. Also, the additional funding for outreach work is not guaranteed. Bring Chicago Home may be defeated at the ballot box, and even if it passes the referendum, it still needs to be crafted into policy and pass the City Council (Weinberg & Woelfel, 2024). This proposed revenue will not come until 2026 at best and never at worst: organizations cannot depend on it yet (Weinberg & Woelfel, 2024).

Conclusion

Uptown has faced historical whiplash. It has gone from a luxurious playground for the wealthy to a neglected village of the working poor, and now it is at risk of becoming an exclusionary neighborhood again. Affordable housing in the neighborhood is disappearing, but there is an opportunity to change that. However, to stop history from repeating itself, urban development must be led by those who have the greatest need. The City of Chicago and private developers have used urban development as a tool to harm Uptown's residents. The first step in healing that harm is ensuring future development is led by those with existing relationships in the community. The goal of sustainable urban development is to improve communities: that is not possible if development raises the cost of living and displaces the people who live there, especially if those people are on the brink of homelessness. For housing to be sustainable, it must be affordable, and urban development has the potential to provide homes for everyone.

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